Operating system security – Lab

CS930 Foundations of Cyber Security

University of Warwick

Work individually, completing the tasks in order. Inspect, predict, choose your commands, then test. Use the Linux command reference on pages 5–6; no command memorisation is needed. Keep useful notes outside the guest. Worked answers will be released later; no formal report is required.

Before starting. Open `https://warwick-cs930.github.io/labs/lecture-03/`.

- Wait for `CHECK PASSED`, `SETUP COMPLETE`, and `LAB READY`.
- Check with `id` that your UID is nonzero. Save the exact `LAB_DIRECTORY:` path and check it against `pwd`. If a check fails, keep the output and ask for help.

Work only in this disposable directory. `exit` or Ctrl-D returns to it with `LAB RESUMED`; if you removed it, a new workspace is created. **Restart lab** or reloading the page discards your work.

Task 1: Implement a file policy

The course team needs two successive policies for `practice.txt`:

- **Review:** the owner may read, but nobody receives write or execute permission. Group and other receive no permissions.
- **Editing:** the owner may read and append. Group and other still receive no permissions; the file remains non-executable.

Use `>>` to preserve existing text throughout the lab. Ordinary write permission allows overwriting too; these modes do not enforce append-only access.

1. Inspect the file's numerical owner and current permissions. Compare the owner with your account and identify which grants conflict with the review policy.
2. Derive the review mode before applying it. Use one `chmod` command, then test both a read and an append. Check that a denied edit leaves the original text intact.
3. Move to the editing policy by adding only the permission now needed. Test both reading and appending again.

Check your understanding: How do the modes explain each read/append result? Why can the owner change permissions on a read-only file?

Task 2: Diagnose an unexpected denial

Inspect `owner-puzzle.txt`, predict whether you can read it, and test before making changes. Evaluate these claims:

> "There is a read bit somewhere in the mode, so the owner can read it."
> "Starting another `cat` process gives it a new PID, so it may gain access."

Use the ownership and mode as evidence. Repair the file so its owner can read and append, with no execute bit or group/other grants. Preserve its contents and test both operations.

Check your understanding: Which permission class explains the result? Why does your repair meet the policy? Would a new PID under the same account change access?

Task 3: Design private creation defaults

New notes must be readable and writable only by their owner. For new directories, only the owner may list names, traverse the directory, and create or remove entries. Text files must not be executable. Choose the **least restrictive creation mask** that meets these requirements.

With no inherited default ACL, ordinary files request `666` and directories request `777`. A mask removes requested bits: `result = requested & ~mask`.

1. Inspect `private-notes.txt`. Derive your mask and predict the two new modes. Predict whether setting the mask will change the existing file's mode.
2. In one subshell, set your mask and create `new-private.txt` with a short note and an empty `new-private-dir`. Do not use `chmod` on these new objects: their initial modes must meet the policy.
3. Inspect all three objects and compare their modes with your predictions. Bring the existing notes into line with the same file policy, preserving their contents. Test reading and appending to both notes files.

Check your understanding: Do the modes match your calculation? Why is the existing file unaffected? Why does one mask give different modes to a file and a directory?

Task 4: Investigate names, links, and deletion

The archive contains an original `report.txt` and a labelled `disposable-copy.txt`. Keep the original report untouched throughout this task.

1. Inspect both files' contents and inode numbers. Are identical contents sufficient evidence that two names refer to the same file?
2. In the lab root, create `duplicate-hard.txt` as a hard link to the disposable copy and `duplicate-soft.txt` as a symbolic link to `archive/disposable-copy.txt`. Inspect all three names and check that both new links can be read.
3. Inspect the archive directory and copy's permissions. Predict whether removing the copy's original name will work, which remaining names will still be readable, and how the hard-link count will change.

Test the prediction by removing **only** the labelled copy's name:

```
rm -f archive/disposable-copy.txt
```

Inspect and read both remaining links. Leave them in place for the final audit; leave the archive directory's mode unchanged for now.

Check your understanding: Did the inode numbers, link counts, and reads match your predictions? Which object's permissions controlled removal? Why do the two links behave differently?

Task 5: Restore a broken editing workflow

An editor cannot use `materials/week-03/briefing.txt` as required. Diagnose the problem from evidence and make the smallest permission changes that satisfy all of these requirements:

- The owner can read the briefing and append a short release decision without losing the original text.
- Both directories in its path remain listable and traversable by the owner.
- Group and other have no grants on these objects; the text file is non-executable.

Reproduce the failed read and append, then decide what to inspect. Change **one object at a time**; retest both operations after each change. Do not replace files, change ownership, or apply recursive permission changes.

Check your understanding: Which object caused each denial? Why does a successful read alone not establish that the workflow is repaired?

Task 6: Enforce an archive policy

The archive must support this combination of operations:

- List its entries and read `report.txt`; preserve the report's original contents and mode.
- Read and directly append to the existing `working-notes.txt`.
- Deny creation and removal of entries inside the archive.
- Give group and other no permissions; do not make text files executable.

A proposed fix is `chmod -R 500 archive`. **Evaluate it on paper only**: name a required operation it would break and an unnecessary grant it would introduce. Then design and apply your own changes using the fewest permission-bit changes needed.

Write a test plan with a command and expected result for each required operation. Include successful reads and a note append, an attempted creation of `archive/new.txt`, and an attempted removal of `archive/report.txt`.

Before testing removal, inspect the archive's final mode and explain why removal should fail. If unsure, ask for help. Only then run `rm -f archive/report.txt` and check that the original report remains readable and unchanged. If removal succeeds, keep the evidence and ask for help; recreating it does not demonstrate protection. Compare all test results with your plan.

Check your understanding: Do the results support your policy? Were the faults unsuitable settings or broken permission checks? Can the owner deliberately undo the freeze?

Task 7: Check your results and clean up

Before finishing, check these outcomes and keep any notes you want to compare with the worked answers:

- The practice, private, owner-puzzle, and briefing files meet their owner-access requirements.
- The states of both links agree with your explanation of names, inodes, and target paths.
- The archive permits reading and direct note appends, while denying entry creation and removal.

What do these experiments establish about one ordinary account? Does a file's broad mode alone prove another account could read it through a private parent directory?

Run `pwd`. Continue only if it matches the exact lab path you kept before starting. Restore directory access and remove only this attempt's named files:

```
chmod u+rwx materials materials/week-03 archive
rm -f practice.txt owner-puzzle.txt private-notes.txt new-private.txt
rm -f duplicate-hard.txt duplicate-soft.txt
rm -f materials/week-03/briefing.txt
rm -f archive/report.txt archive/disposable-copy.txt
rm -f archive/working-notes.txt archive/new.txt
rmdir materials/week-03 materials archive
rmdir new-private-dir
cd ..
```

Omit `rmdir new-private-dir` if you did not create it. The `-f` option ignores missing files. Finally use `rmdir` with the **exact lab-directory name from the end of your saved path**. If it is nonempty, inspect what remains with the instructor; do not use wildcards or recursive deletion.

Linux command reference

Uppercase words such as `FILE`, `DIR`, `PATH`, and `MODE` are placeholders: replace them with a name or value. `PATH` can name a file or directory. Do not type a prompt such as `$`. Run one command per line and press Enter.

Navigate and inspect

`archive/report.txt` is relative to your current directory; a path starting with `/` is absolute. `.` means the current directory; `..` means its parent. Keep the shell in the lab root.

Command	Meaning
`pwd`	Print the current directory's absolute path.
`id`	Show your user ID (UID), primary group, and group memberships.
`cd DIR`; `cd ..`	Change directory; move to the parent directory.
`ls DIR`	List directory entries. In this guest, requires read and search permission; see the note below.
`ls -l PATH`	Long listing: type/permissions, hard-link count, owner, group, size, date, and name. For a directory, list its entries; see the read/search note below.
`ls -ld DIR`	Inspect the directory itself, rather than its contents.
`ls -ln FILE`	Long listing with numerical owner and group IDs, for comparison with `id`.
`ls -li FILE`	Long listing with the inode number added at the start. Compare inode numbers and hard-link counts.
`cat FILE`	Display a file's contents. A failed read prints an error.

Combine options: `ls -ldn DIR` inspects a directory with numerical IDs. `ls`, `cat`, `chmod`, `rm`, and `rmdir` accept several paths, as in `cat FILE1 FILE2` or `chmod MODE PATH1 PATH2`. A symbolic link's listing includes `NAME -> TARGET`.

Directory read versus search. Read (`r`) permits reading entry names; search (`x`) permits looking them up. This guest's BusyBox `ls` also looks up entries, so it may print denials instead of names when `r` is set without `x`. Use `ls -ld DIR` to inspect the directory itself.

Read and change permission bits

In `-rw-r-----`, the first character gives the type: `-` file, `d` directory, `l` symbolic link. The next three triplets are owner, group, and other. Add granted bits for each numerical digit: `r = 4`, `w = 2`, `x = 1`; `-` adds zero. For example, `r-x` is `5`.

Command	Meaning
`chmod MODE PATH`	Set all three ordinary permission classes using a three-digit octal mode. Choose the digits to match the policy.
`chmod u+w PATH`	Add owner write permission; preserve the other bits.
`chmod u-w PATH`	Remove owner write permission; preserve the other bits. For example, `chmod u-w DIR` changes a directory.
`chmod u+x DIR`	Add owner directory-search permission.
`chmod g=r FILE`	Set the group class to read only, replacing its existing grants.
`chmod go-rwx PATH`	Remove all group and other permissions.

Symbolic modes use `u` (owner), `g` (group), `o` (other), or `a` (all), then `+`, `-`, or `=`. Combine letters, as in `u+rw`, or changes, as in `u+r,g-w`. `chmod -R` applies changes recursively; evaluate the Task 6 proposal without running it.

Linux command reference (continued)

Create files and directories

`printf` prints text. The shell's `>` and `>>` operators send that text to a file. Quotes keep the message together; `\n` inside the format string adds a newline.

Command or shell syntax	Meaning
`printf 'A short note\n'`	Print a message and a newline in the terminal.
`printf 'A note\n' > NEWFILE`	Create a file containing the message. **If it exists, `>` truncates its old contents.** Use this only for a named new file.
`printf 'An edit\n' >> FILE`	Append a message, keeping existing contents. Read the file afterward to check the result.
`touch NEWFILE`	Create an empty file if the name is absent. If it exists, update its timestamps without erasing the text.
`mkdir DIR`	Create a directory.
`umask`	Display the current creation mask.
`umask MASK`	Set the mask for subsequent creations by this shell and its child processes. Existing objects keep their modes.

An append creates the file if its name is absent; check path spelling. Write permission also allows overwriting; `>>` preserves existing text.

Recognise denials. A failed read may say `can't open ...: Permission denied`; a failed append may say `can't create ...: Permission denied`, even for an existing file. These are access denials, not missing-file errors. Keep using the ordinary account.

Use a temporary mask in a subshell

Parentheses run a subshell; its mask changes do not alter the surrounding shell. Replace `MASK`, `NEWFILE`, and `NEWDIR` with your choices.

```
(
    umask MASK
    printf 'A new note\n' > NEWFILE
    mkdir NEWDIR
)
```

Finish the block, including the closing parenthesis, before inspecting results. Semicolons separate commands on one line: `( umask MASK; touch NEWFILE )`.

Create links and remove names

Command	Meaning
`ln SOURCE NEWNAME`	Create a hard link: another name for the same file.
`ln -s TARGET NEWNAME`	Create a symbolic link storing `TARGET`. A relative target is interpreted from the directory containing the link.
`rm -f FILE`	Remove a named file or link. `-f` suppresses prompts and missing-name errors; it does not override permissions. Removing a symlink removes the link, not its target.
`rmdir DIR`	Remove an empty directory. A nonempty directory is left intact.

For cleanup, follow Task 7 using only named disposable objects; no wildcards or recursive deletion. Keep useful notes outside the guest before restarting the machine.